FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

A bureaucrat's competence, dedication or leadership has nothing to do with the shade of their skin. Yet, India's deeply rooted bias around skin colour doesn't spare anyone, not even those at the very top of the administrative ladder. Take the case of Sarada Muraleedharan, a respected Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer from the 1990 batch. In September 2024, she took charge as Kerala's Chief Secretary, stepping into the role after her husband and fellow officer V. Venu. While comparisons between the two might have been expected, the kind she encountered revealed something far more insidious. In a heartfelt Facebook post on March 25, she recounted a comment someone made about her work: "It is as black as my husband's was white." Her response wasn't defensive. It was reflective and deeply moving. "I need to own my blackness," she wrote, going on to share her lifelong journey of dealing with colour-based bias. She gave a poignant description of how, as a four-year-old, she once asked her mother if she could be born again, "white and pretty". Her post went viral, sparking a flood of emotions and discussions across the country. It touched a raw nerve because far too many Indians, especially women, have lived similar experiences.



This bias isn't new. It begins in school playgrounds and seeps in everywhere—from boardrooms to the choice of life partners. The market for skin lightening products, expected to reach Rs 20,500 crore by 2030, reflects how pervasive and profitable this prejudice has become. The bias doesn't stop at beauty standards. It affects how people are treated in classrooms, offices, and media spaces. A 2018 study found that 70 per cent of matrimonial ads from women or their families highlighted fairness as a desirable trait. Among men, over 60 per cent actively sought fair-skinned brides. Even popular platforms like shaadi.com featured a skin tone scale until they were called out and were forced to take it down.

The irony is that many of our revered deities, like Krishna, Shiva and Ram, are described as dark-skinned in the epics. So is Draupadi, the radiant queen of the Mahabharata. But somewhere along the way, through colonial legacies and warped ideals, we started equating light skin with beauty, worth and success.

The media and entertainment industry hasn't helped. Fair-skinned actors are favoured, and many others have their appearances altered, digitally or in the old days through make-up, to fit the ideal mould. And when someone like model and actress Poulomi Das, gorgeous and talented, loses out on a leading role in a television show just because of her skin tone, it reminds us that not much has changed.

Worse still, this pressure weighs heaviest on women. As if managing professional excellence wasn't enough, they are often judged on how well they fit a visual stereotype.

Why is this bias so hard to shake off? Because it is embedded in our history. Sociologist Vivek Kumar points to the ancient encounter between the Aryans and the Dravidians and later our colonial subjugation. Radhika Parameswaran, a professor at The Media School, Indiana University, says the obsession has only intensified with social media. She argues that real change must begin early, in schools, before children absorb these harmful standards.

This week's cover story explores colourism from many angles, data, lived experiences, history, and science. Executive Editor Manisha Saroop threads together multiple bureau inputs on stories that are raw, real and hopeful. Stories like that of assistant director Snigdha Nair, who fought back against internalised shame by making a short film titled *You*. Her words stay with you: "It's not a deformity, it's normal."

Because yes, this is our normal. Dark skin is not an aberration. It is our origin. Our ancestors evolved dark skin to survive the sun. Fairness, biologically, is more vulnerable. In fact, light-skinned individuals are up to 70 times more likely to develop skin cancer.

The truth is simple. The problem isn't skin colour. It's how we perceive it. If we want to move forward as a society, we need to stop letting our biases speak louder than our values.

Because in the end, the real ugliness isn't in someone's complexion. It's in the eye that refuses to see their humanity.

It is better to kill your bias than be killed by it. The ugliness lies in the mind of the beholder.

(Aroon Purie)